

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Individual Development Plan

Turn a skills gap into a specific, time-bound growth plan that the engineer actually owns.

Purpose

An Individual Development Plan (IDP) converts "you should grow" into a concrete, agreed set of objectives, actions and success measures for one person over a defined period. It exists to make development deliberate rather than accidental, and to make it the engineer's plan — co-authored with you, not handed down.

When to use it

- After a skills-matrix calibration, to act on what it revealed.
- Following a promotion conversation, to define the gap to the next level.
- When someone is stalled, bored or at risk of leaving — an IDP is a retention tool as much as a growth tool.
- For a new hire, to structure their first six months beyond onboarding.
- Reviewed at least quarterly. An IDP set once a year is a formality; one revisited every quarter is a habit.

Instructions

1. Start from evidence (the skills matrix, recent work, the person's own ambitions), not a template of generic goals.
2. Pick two to three development areas. More than three and nothing moves.
3. Write each objective so it is specific and measurable — "reach Working level on API contract testing, evidenced by owning the contract tests for one service" beats "get better at APIs".
4. For each objective, agree concrete actions, the support you will provide, and how you will both know it is done.
5. Balance stretch with wellbeing. Development that piles onto an already-overloaded person is a plan to burn them out.
6. Set review dates and actually keep them.

Worked example

An IDP for Dan Whitmore, Northstar's automation engineer. Context from the skills matrix: he is the sole owner of UI automation and CI/CD (key-person risk), is isolated, is quietly burning out on the flaky Selenium suite, and is

weak on stakeholder communication and mentoring. The plan deliberately spreads his load rather than adding to it.

Field	Detail
Engineer	Dan Whitmore
Current role / level	Automation Engineer (mid-senior)
Period	Q3-Q4 (6 months), reviewed monthly
Strengths to build on	Strong UI automation and CI/CD; genuine enthusiasm for tooling.
Career direction	Towards a technical leadership / test-architecture path, not people management.

Development objective 1 — reduce key-person risk (and his own load)

Element	Detail
Objective	Move from sole owner to lead-and-teacher of UI automation: at least two other engineers able to run, debug and extend the suite independently.
Why	Removes the single point of failure the skills matrix flagged, and relieves the workload driving his burnout.
Actions	Run a fortnightly automation clinic for the team; pair with Grace and Hassan on real failures; document the top-10 flaky tests and the fix pattern for each.
Support from lead	Protected time (half a day a week ring-fenced); back him publicly so squads treat automation as shared, not "Dan's job".
Success measure	Two named engineers merge automation fixes unaided; suite flakiness trend reviewed monthly and moving down.

Development objective 2 — stakeholder communication (matrix score 1 → target 2)

Element	Detail
Objective	Present the automation health picture to the squads in plain, risk-focused language once a fortnight.
Actions	Co-prepare the first two updates with Sofia; use a simple red/amber/green format; focus on what the flakiness costs the team, not test counts.
Support from lead	Coaching before each session; introduce him to Priya (VP Eng) so his work is visible upwards.
Success measure	Delivers two updates solo; a squad lead references the automation health picture in planning without prompting.

Wellbeing check (explicit, not an afterthought)

- Current on-call/maintenance load reviewed and capped while objective 1 spreads ownership.
- Monthly one-to-one includes an explicit "how sustainable is your week?" question.
- This plan must reduce his total load over six months, not add a third full-time job.

How to interpret the results

- Progress is evidenced by changed behaviour and outcomes, not activity. "Ran three clinics" is input; "two engineers now fix automation unaided" is the result.
- If an objective has not moved in two consecutive reviews, the blocker is usually time, not will — fix the time.
- A completed IDP should visibly reduce a risk on your skills matrix or move someone toward the next rung of your progression framework. If it does neither, it was busywork.

Blank reusable version

Field	Detail
Engineer	
Current role / level	
Period / review cadence	
Strengths to build on	
Career direction	

Repeat the block below for each of your two or three objectives:

Element	Detail
Objective (specific + measurable)	
Why it matters	
Actions	
Support from manager	
Success measure / evidence	
Target date	

Always finish with an explicit wellbeing/load check.

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Setting five objectives so that none of them move. Writing goals so vague ("improve communication") that nobody can tell when they are met. Making it the manager’s plan for the person rather than the person’s plan for themselves. Loading development on top of an already-saturated week and calling the resulting burnout a "motivation problem". Filing it after the meeting and never opening it until the next annual review.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

The best development plans quietly de-risk the team at the same time as growing the person. Dan’s plan does not just make Dan happier — it dismantles the single point of failure his skills represent. Look for those double wins first.